

SHRIYA PATIL, SHINDE

NISHTHA NAGCHOUHDHURY'S
mother feeds her
13-year-old daughter as
her make-up is redone
between shoots



No Time for INNOCENCE

Circus artistes or cash cows? Children, some as young as eight, are being brazenly used to enhance ratings for reality shows. And the Government has only now woken up to it.

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Long before the Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) decided to investigate the long working hours of participants on reality shows on television, there was a show called *Boogie Woogie* on Sony (at 500 episodes and counting, over 12 years, perhaps the longest running in the genre) featuring tiny boys and girls shaking their invisible hips and thrusting their non-existent breasts. No one protested then. When Zee TV's *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Li'l Champs* finale scored a TRP of 11.1 in its first season in 2006, no one protested then too. Now, when the platforms have multiplied and the rewards are all too evident for pushy parents and clamorous children, the NCPCR seems to have woken up to the issue of guidelines.

And about time too. Two big-ticket children's reality shows have already been wrapped up this year (*Li'l Champs* and its clone *Star Voice of India Chhote Ustad*, which was crafted on Star Plus by the originator of the series on Zee TV, Gajendra Singh). Currently, two such shows are on air and another is all set to follow soon. Just as controversy erupted last year when CBS ran *Kid Nation*—a reality show where children try to create a functioning society in a town shot in New Mexico—the lid seems to have blown off television's best-kept secret. That the shows that get the small screen some of its highest ratings are no better than one long drudge where children, some as young as eight, are forced to behave like adults in front of the camera, lose their innocence and work in at least 12-hour shifts a day,

but gain in big bucks. It's causing breakdowns, as when the 12-year-old Anamika Choudhary, who won *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Li'l Champs* in 2007, broke down in the middle of her performance because she couldn't handle the news of co-contestant Smita Nandi's father suffering a heart-attack after his daughter was eliminated from the show. And walkouts, as when Pritam stormed out of *Chhote Ustad* when a member of the audience kissed celebrity guest Emraan Hashmi. He found the act inappropriate for a children's show. Indeed, children are being used, as a *Variety* columnist said earlier, as fodder for fun and profit.

Take Tanu Srivastava, all of nine, from Azamgarh in Uttar Pradesh, the daughter of a government official and homemaker. She could easily be mistaken for a promising television